

Ralston cereal jumped on the bandwagon with radio show premiums like Tom Mix rings, badges, and toys that could be obtained with box tops.

Premium offers diminished in the 1940s when the United States went to war and basic goods became scarce and essentials rationed, but re-emerged in the early 1950s in a postwar economy that flourished. To appeal to the 1950s housewife, detergent and soap companies were prolific in their choice of premiums. Coverage of the New York Premium Show in a September 1963 issue of *The New York Times* mentions personalized notepads, dishes, spoons, and flatware, along with a send-in premium of a mink stole valued at \$595. All a shopper had to do was mail in three wrappers from Underwood deviled ham to own it. Three wrappers and a check for \$345, that is. In an eBay search for 1950s soap premiums I discovered a wide variety of dishes and flatware that had either been inside or attached to the box, or given free at the point of sale. In an era when televised soap operas were sponsored by detergent and soap companies (hence the name), homemakers sometimes found themselves choosing a certain brand of detergent just for the free towel or dishcloth included inside the box, just as their foremothers chose feed sacks for their color and design for future sewing projects.

Perhaps one of the more creative promotions of all time was in 1969, when a marketer with the Procter & Gamble Company came up with the idea of giving away goldfish with each purchase of a king-size box of Spic and Span. Rod Taylor relates in a June 2005 *Promo* magazine that planning the national promotion took over a year and called for more than a million goldfish. Once they devised a method of shipping the live fish to the stores